



Introduction

Managing varroa mites often involves handling substances that can irritate the skin, eyes, or airways if used incorrectly. While the focus of varroa management is usually on protecting bees, it is equally important to protect yourself.

This guide explains the role of Personal Protective Equipment (PPE) when dealing with varroa treatments in the UK. It is intended to help beekeepers understand common risks and make informed decisions about personal safety.

Important: PPE requirements vary between products. Always follow the instructions and safety information on the product label.



BEFORE YOU START

Even products described as “natural” can still irritate the skin if used incorrectly.

Always read the product label before use



WHO IS THIS GUIDE FOR?

- ✓ Hobby beekeepers
- ✓ Association members
- ✓ Beginners
- ✓ Experienced beekeepers



WHY PPE MATTERS IN BEEKEEPING

Many varroa treatments are classed as veterinary medicines. Even “natural” products described as “natural” can still pose risks if they:

- Come into contact with skin or eyes
- Are inhaled as vapour or dust
- Are handled repeatedly without protection

Using appropriate PPE:

- ✓ Reduces the risk of short-term injury or irritation
- ✓ Helps prevent long-term health effects
- ✓ Encourages safe, consistent working practices



TYPICAL RISKS WHEN HANDLING VARROA TREATMENTS

Depending on the treatment type and method of application, potential risks may include:



Skin irritation or absorption



Eye irritation or splashes



Breathing in vapours, aerosols, or dust



Contaminating clothing or hands



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READ THE FULL GUIDE

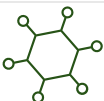
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PPE Considerations by Treatment Type (Overview)

The table below gives general, descriptive guidance. It does not replace product instructions.

TREATMENT TYPE	TYPICAL RISKS	COMMON PPE CONSIDERATIONS *
 Organic acids (e.g. oxalic acid, formic acid)	Skin, eye and respiratory irritation	Gloves, eye protection; respiratory protection may be required depending on method and ventilation
 Thymol-based treatments	Skin and eye irritation	Gloves; avoid direct contact; wash hands after handling
 Amitraz-based treatments	Skin absorption	Gloves; avoid prolonged skin contact; follow label instructions carefully
 Pyrethroid-based treatments	Skin irritation	Gloves; wash hands after handling; avoid contamination of tools/clothing

*Always follow the product label and current UK guidance

COMMON TYPES OF PPE USED BY BEEKEEPERS



GLOVES

Disposable gloves (such as nitrile) are widely used when handling treatments. Good practice Includes

- Use clean gloves for each task
- Avoiding reuse of disposable gloves
- Removing gloves before touching tools, phones, or vehicles



EYE PROTECTION

Eye protection helps prevent splashes or accidental contact. This may be particularly relevant when

- Handling liquids
- Working at awkward angles
- Applying treatments in windy conditions



RESPIRATORY PROTECTION

Some treatments may release vapours, aerosols, or dust. Key points

- may be recommended for certain products or methods
- check the product label for specific requirements
- Avoid treating in enclosed or poorly ventilated spaces



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PROTECTIVE CLOTHING

Long sleeves and dedicated beekeeping clothing can:

- ✓ Reduce skin exposure
- ✓ Prevent contamination of everyday clothes
- ✓ Wash contaminated clothing separately from household laundry.

HYGIENE AND AFTERCARE

After handling varroa treatments:



Wash hands thoroughly with soap and water



Avoid touching your face until hands are clean



Dispose of used PPE appropriately



Clean any contaminated tools according to guidance



Good hygiene reduces accidental exposure long after the task is finished



ENVIRONMENTAL & SITUATIONAL FACTORS

Even with PPE, working conditions matter. Pay attention to:

- ✓ Wind direction and strength
- ✓ Temperature (which may affect vapours)
- ✓ Children, pets or bystanders nearby
- ✓ Working in confined spaces (sheds, small apiaries)

If conditions are unsuitable, delay treatment where possible

STORAGE AND DISPOSAL SAFETY



Store treatments securely and out of reach of children



Keep products in original containers with labels intact



Dispose of empty packaging and used PPE according to local guidance



Never reuse containers unless the label explicitly allows it



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Safe Handling, Hygiene, Storage & Disposal

Good practice does not end with PPE. Working conditions, hygiene and safe storage all reduce the risk of accidental exposure when using varroa treatments.



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KEY SAFETY PRINCIPLES & FURTHER READING

Important reminders for safe varroa treatment use



KEY SAFETY PRINCIPLES TO REMEMBER



PPE supports safe use – it does not replace correct use



Labels and instructions come first



If unsure, stop and seek advice



Safe habits protect both beekeeper and bees



OFFICIAL GUIDANCE AND FURTHER READING



National Bee Unit / BeeBase

<https://www.nationalbeeunit.com>



Veterinary Medicines Directorate (VMD)

<https://www.gov.uk/government/organisations/veterinary-medicines-directorate>



British Beekeepers Association

<https://www.bbka.org.uk>



BeezKnees – Varroa Management

<https://beezknees.co.uk/varroa-management>



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The table below provides a quick-reference summary of the typical risks associated with some commonly used varroa treatments and the types of personal protective equipment (PPE) or precautions that may be appropriate when handling them. It is intended to bring together the main points covered in this guide and help beekeepers consider the potential for skin, eye or respiratory exposure before starting a treatment.

PPE checklist (summary)		
Treatment type	Typical risks	Common PPE considerations*
Organic acids (e.g. oxalic acid, formic acid)	Skin, eye and respiratory irritation	Gloves, eye protection; respiratory protection may be required depending on method and ventilation.
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